

The Battle of Gettysburg

Decide whether the three-day battle of July 1863 — together with Vicksburg — was the turning point that changed the direction of the Civil War.

? Historical challenge

In July 1863, Confederate General Robert E. Lee invaded the North and met the Union army at Gettysburg, Pennsylvania, in the largest battle ever fought in North America. Why do historians call this three-day battle a turning point of the Civil War? Map what led up to it and what changed afterward.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Gettysburg Overview – Gettysburg National Military Park (NPS)

SECONDARY SOURCE

The three days of battle and their staggering cost.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How many casualties did the battle produce?
- Why was the outcome so important?

SOURCES 2

The Gettysburg Address – Library of Congress

PRIMARY SOURCE

Lincoln's short speech dedicating the cemetery months after the battle.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did Lincoln describe the meaning of the war?
- Why give such a speech at a battlefield cemetery?

SOURCES 3

Emancipation Proclamation – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The January 1863 order that reframed the war's purpose.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did the Proclamation change the war's meaning?
- How does it connect to the Gettysburg Address?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

BEFORE	Who pushed toward this point?
↓	
PRESSURES BUILDING	Who resisted?
↓	
TURNING POINT The Battle of Gettysburg · July 1–3, 1863	Could events have gone differently?
↓	
IMMEDIATE RESULTS	
↓	
LONGER-TERM CHANGE	
Why could this be a turning point?	

Sources 1 Sources 2 Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your before-and-after with a partner. Did you agree on what changed most?
- Which pressure do you think mattered most in leading to the battle?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was Gettysburg truly a turning point? Use evidence from at least two sources to argue what changed after it — pairing it with Vicksburg — that could not be undone.